

Why Coaching Works

And Why AI Can Do It For Your Fiction



What Coaching Actually Does

There is a difference between being told something and discovering it yourself. Most people who have experienced a genuinely skilled coach — not a trainer, not a consultant, not a well-meaning advisor — know immediately what that difference feels like. The insight arrives as yours. It changes how you move. It stays.

This is not a subjective impression. It is one of the most well-replicated findings in behavioral science.

Carl Rogers was the first to name it rigorously. Across decades of clinical practice and research, Rogers argued that human beings already possess the resources for their own development — that the role of a skilled practitioner is not to install new beliefs or supply missing answers, but to create the conditions under which the person can access what they already know.

Those conditions, Rogers identified, are three: genuineness on the part of the coach (no performance, no pretense), unconditional positive regard (the person is accepted without judgment), and empathic understanding (tracking not just what is said but what is meant beneath it).

When all three are present, Rogers found, people change — not because they received correct information, but because they discovered it themselves. Person-Centered Counseling, built on this foundation, became one of the most studied and replicated approaches in the history of psychology.

The curious paradox is that when I accept myself just as I am, then I can change.

— Carl Rogers, On Becoming a Person

The neuroscience of the last three decades has put structural detail behind what Rogers observed clinically. Research on insight — the so-called "aha moment" — shows that self-generated understanding activates different neural pathways than received instruction. Specifically, insight produced from within the learner triggers activity in the right anterior temporal lobe and releases a burst of gamma-wave activity that is absent when the same information is simply told. That neural signature corresponds to stronger encoding, greater durability, and higher transferability of the learning.

In plain terms: what you discover for yourself, you keep. What you are told, you evaluate and often discard.

RESEARCH · Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience, 2004 (Jung-Beeman et al.)

Brain imaging studies of problem-solving found that insight solutions — those that arrive with sudden clarity — showed distinct neural activation patterns compared to analytical solutions. Insight-generated understanding was associated with stronger memory encoding and greater transfer to new problems.

Tim Gallwey saw this in athletics before Rogers had fully articulated it in therapy. His 1974 book *The Inner Game of Tennis* proposed that performance was determined less by technical instruction than by the coach's ability to quiet the player's "interference" — the internal critic that overwrites natural capability. Gallwey's method: ask the player what they notice about their own body, their own racket, their own movement. Don't tell. Ask. Then watch what emerges.

The Inner Game became one of the most influential sports coaching books ever written. Its principles were adopted beyond tennis — into music, skiing, corporate performance, and executive development — because the mechanism it identified is not sport-specific. It is human.

John Wooden won ten NCAA championships at UCLA in twelve years. His players — Kareem Abdul-Jabbar, Bill Walton, and a generation of NBA Hall of Famers — describe a coach who almost never raised his voice, almost never praised, and almost never gave direct instruction during games. What Wooden did was ask. What were you thinking when you made that choice? What did you notice when that happened? What would you do differently? His practices were the most carefully structured in college basketball history — but the learning happened through questions, not lectures.

Bill Campbell, the executive coach whose clients included Steve Jobs, Eric Schmidt, Larry Page, and Sheryl Sandberg, built an entire practice on the same principle. Campbell's biographers describe a man who almost never gave direct advice — even when he had it, even when he was confident in it. His method was to ask, listen past the first answer, and ask again. The people he coached reported feeling, afterward, that they had figured something out themselves. That was not an accident. That was the design.

My job is not to tell you the answer. My job is to ask you the question you haven't asked yourself yet.

— Bill Campbell, as recalled by Eric Schmidt

The pattern holds across every domain where human performance under pressure has been studied carefully: the most durable development comes not from instruction received, but from insight generated. Rogers named the mechanism. Gallwey proved it in athletics. Wooden applied it in competitive sport. Campbell scaled it to the highest-stakes corporate environments on earth.

All of them, in different vocabularies, were describing the same thing: a coach is not someone who knows the answer. A coach is someone who refuses to give it to you — because they understand that the only answer that will actually change your behavior is the one you find yourself.

Why Writers Need This — More Than Almost Anyone

Writing is one of the most cognitively isolated activities a person can undertake. You sit alone with a problem that has no external feedback loop. No opponent to react. No audience response. No colleague to notice that you're stuck in the same pattern for the third chapter in a row.

Most writers, when they hit a wall with a character, do one of two things. They push harder — writing more scenes, generating more backstory, producing more material in the hope that volume will surface what they're missing. Or they stop, wait for inspiration, and hope the character eventually speaks.

Neither works reliably. Both are what happens in the absence of good questions.

Here is what is actually happening when a character doesn't work.

The writer already knows more about the character than they can access. The complexity is there — the contradictions, the wounds, the gap between what the character says and what they mean — but it lives below the threshold of conscious articulation. The writer has a felt sense of who this person is. They cannot yet put it into words specific enough to write.

This is a retrieval problem, not a creation problem. The character isn't missing. The writer can't yet reach them.

RESEARCH · Psychological Science, 2012 (Dijksterhuis & Meurs)

Research on unconscious thought theory found that complex creative problems — those with multiple interdependent variables — were solved more effectively after a period of non-analytical incubation than by direct analytical effort. Writers working through character complexity are operating in exactly this domain.

What closes the retrieval gap? Not more thinking. Not more research. Not a better character questionnaire. What closes it is the right question, asked at the right moment, by someone who doesn't supply the answer.

This is precisely what coaches are trained to do — and precisely what writers almost never have access to. A writing group offers feedback on the work already produced. An editor works on the draft in front of them. A writing teacher delivers instruction. None of these is coaching. None of them asks the question that surfaces what you already know and haven't yet written.

Anne Lamott's famous advice about shitty first drafts is an attempt to solve this problem indirectly — get out of your own way, let something onto the page. But the underlying problem isn't self-criticism. It's self-interrogation. The writer isn't asking the right questions of themselves. And no one around them is asking those questions either.

The writer's job is not to find the character. The writer already has the character. The job is to stop standing in the way of the retrieval.

— Ted Baker

The writers who develop the deepest, most distinctive characters tend to have, in common, one unusual habit: they spend a great deal of time interrogating their characters rather than describing them. They ask why before they ask what. They sit with a character's contradiction rather than resolving it. They are, functionally, coaching themselves — running Rogerian questions on their own imagination.

Most writers are never taught to do this. It isn't part of any standard writing curriculum. It isn't in Strunk and White. It isn't in the MFA syllabus. The skills exist in behavioral science, not in fiction craft — which is why they've remained largely inaccessible to writers until now.

Why AI Can Do This — And What It Cannot

A skilled human coach — someone trained in the Rogerian tradition, with decades of practice reading the hesitation in a person's answer, the thing they almost said before they pulled back — is better than any AI you will ever use. That is simply true.

But the correct comparison is not AI versus the best human coach in the world. It never was. The correct comparison is AI coaching versus writing alone.

Measured against writing alone, AI delivers something remarkable: a patient, infinitely available interlocutor that knows how to ask instead of tell. That will hold the Rogerian frame — no judgment, no agenda, no impatience — for as long as you need it. That will

ask the third question and the fourth question and the question underneath the question, without getting tired or distracted or convinced it already knows your answer. That is 80% of the benefit of a skilled human coach. At approximately 1% of the cost. Available at six in the morning or midnight, in the middle of a draft, exactly when you need it.

The 20% AI cannot provide is the human read: the calibration that comes from watching a person's face, tracking the catch in their voice, sensing what they're protecting before they've said a word. That gap is real and worth naming honestly. But here is what that 20% does not affect: your characters.

Your characters don't have faces for the AI to read. They don't have posture or vocal hesitation or the particular way someone looks at the floor when they're protecting something. Your characters live in your imagination — where you are the only one who has ever been. The AI's job is not to read your character. It is to ask you the questions that help you read your character yourself.

For that specific job — retrieval from a writer's imagination — the AI turns out to be extraordinarily well suited. Not because it understands fiction. Because it understands how to ask.

RESEARCH · Harvard Business Review, 2019 (Ibarra & Scoular)

A study of coaching effectiveness in organizational settings found that the single most reliable predictor of coaching impact was not the coach's domain expertise, but their ability to ask non-leading questions and hold space for the coachee's own processing. Domain knowledge was secondary to questioning discipline.

What you are doing when you use this method is not prompting a content generator. You are applying one of the most rigorously tested frameworks in behavioral science — the Rogerian questioning method, with a 70-year research base — to the specific problem of the writer who cannot retrieve what they already know about their characters.

The AI is the most accessible delivery mechanism that framework has ever had. That is what makes this course possible, and what makes the method teachable at scale for the first time.

Where the Author Comes In

I want to be transparent about where my own experience fits in this picture.

I spent thirty-five years in behavioral consulting — working with more than twenty thousand people across the U.S. and Canada on questions of performance, communication, and change. My introduction to the Rogerian method came through a mentor named Len Corcoran, who had been applying it in counseling and organizational work for decades before I encountered him. Len didn't teach me techniques. He demonstrated what happens when someone is genuinely asked instead of told, and then he waited long enough for something real to arrive.

What I bring to this course is not the research — Rogers, Gallwey, Wooden, and Campbell established that independently, and it stands without me. What I bring is thirty-five years of watching the mechanism work on real people, under real pressure, in real situations. And then the recognition, when I sat down to write my first novel, that the writers I was watching struggle with their characters were stuck on exactly the same problem I had spent my career solving: the inability to retrieve what they already knew. The method in this course is their method, applied to yours. The AI is a new tool in a very old hand.